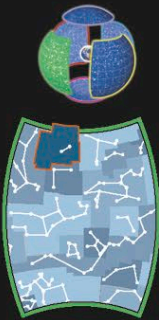


THE HUNTING DOGS

Canes Venatici



SIZE RANKING 38

BRIGHTEST STAR  
Cor Caroli (α) 2.9

GENITIVE Canum  
Venaticorum

ABBREVIATION CVn

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM  
April–May

FULLY VISIBLE  
90°N–37°S



Canes Venatici lies in the northern sky between Boötes and Ursa Major. This constellation represents two dogs held on a leash by the herdsman Boötes. It was formed by Johannes Hevelius (see p.384) at the end of the 17th century from stars that had previously been part of Ursa Major.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

The constellation's brightest star, Alpha (α) Canum Venaticorum, is known as Cor Caroli, meaning Charles's Heart, in commemoration of King Charles I of England. This wide double star, with components of magnitudes 2.9 and 5.6, is easily separated with a small telescope. The brighter star is slightly variable, by about one-tenth of a magnitude, which is too small to be noticeable to the naked eye. Larger variation is found in Y Canum Venaticorum, a deep red supergiant popularly known as La Superba. It fluctuates between magnitudes 5.0 and 6.5 every 160 days or so.

THE SUNFLOWER GALAXY

M63 is a spiral galaxy with patchy outer arms that is seen at an angle from Earth. The arms give rise to comparisons with the appearance of a sunflower. The star to its right in this photograph is of 9th magnitude.



THE WHIRLPOOL GALAXY

The core of this beautiful spiral galaxy (also known as M51) appears as a point of light in a small telescope, as does its companion galaxy NGC 5195 (top) at the end of one arm.

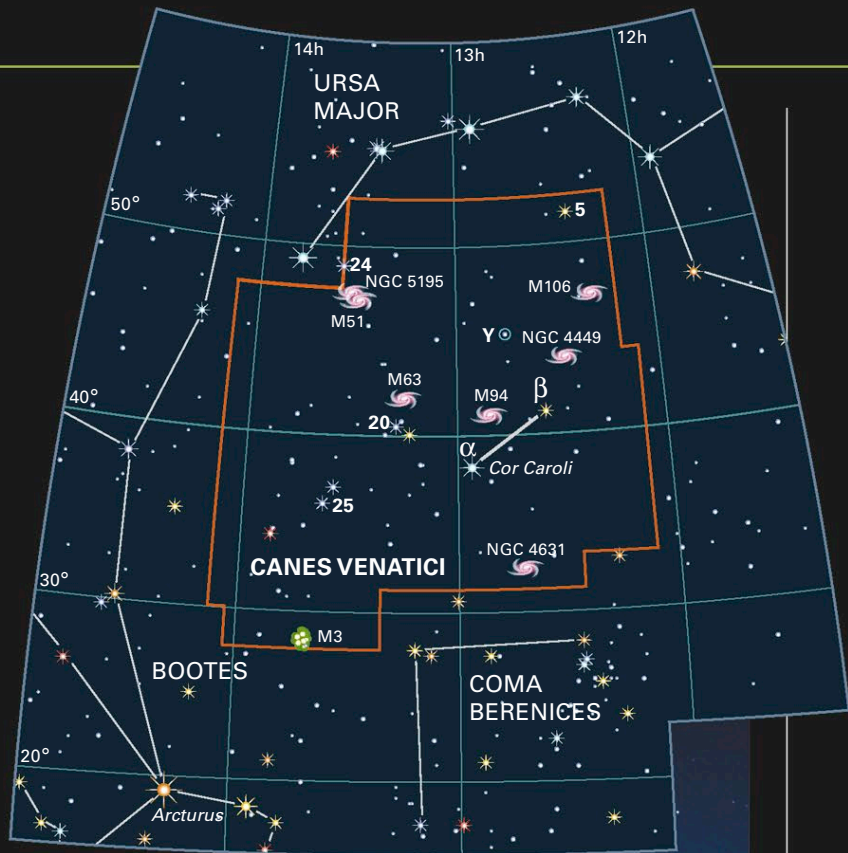
Canes Venatici also contains some fine galaxies, such as the Whirlpool Galaxy (see p.315), or M51, which is found seven diameters of a full moon from the star at the end of the handle of the Big Dipper (in Ursa Major). The Whirlpool Galaxy was the first galaxy in which spiral form was detected—the observation being made in 1845 by William Parsons (see p.315) in Ireland. The galaxy appears as a round patch of light through binoculars, but a moderate-sized telescope is needed to make out the spiral arms. At the end of one of the arms lies a smaller galaxy, NGC 5195, which is passing close to M51.

Two spiral galaxies worth looking for through a small telescope are the Sunflower Galaxy (M63) and M94.



GLOBULAR CLUSTER M3

This cluster is one of the biggest and brightest globular clusters in the northern sky. A telescope with a 4-in (100-mm) aperture is needed to resolve its individual stars.



THE HUNTING DOGS



TWO BRIGHT STARS

Canes Venatici represents a pair of hounds, but the unaided eye can see little more than the constellation's brightest stars, Cor Caroli and Beta Canum Venaticorum.